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Put the smallest things on your calendar

By The Medium Blog

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“I need a deadline,” a friend of mine used to say when they were struggling to get something done. They knew they could do it, but if given seemingly infinite time they never would.

I feel the same way. All the time. (Right now, actually, I’m writing this on a 30-minute deadline before a meeting.) My “timeboxing” habit—aka setting aside 30min or one-hour blocks for various tasks so I actually get them done—started during the pandemic, when time felt expansive and neverending (in an overwhelming and kind of depressing way!). Since then, I’ve used my calendar more or less as a reminder service, with to-dos stacked on top of each other for 30 minutes each. It’s a way to turn Parkinson’s Law (work expands to fill available time) to my advantage.

Way back in the Medium archive, design leader David Sherwin shared his personal approach to developing short “sprints” for yourself so you can do things you care about. He adds some nuance to the habit, encouraging you to set super small chunks of time aside to get things done—think, 10 minutes or less. This compressed span of time is a true “time box.” “The more time you give yourself

in a time box,” he writes, “the less likely you’ll be able to finish the task.”

Sherwin notes that 10 minutes obviously isn’t enough to complete a complex task (like writing an entire newsletter) but it is enough to do one highly defined piece of it—like developing an outline.

In Harvard Business Review, Neha Kirpalani cites one more advantage to mincing your day into small bits and noting them on your calendar: you’ll remember what you did. You’ll be able to look back at it tomorrow, next month, or next year. You’ll be able to, in Kirpalani’s words, better reflect upon and better articulate how you’ve spent your life.

—Harris Sockel